

KEEP MOVING.

YOUR EXERCISE FOR CANCER CARE GUIDE

Exercise is now core cancer care, not something to avoid. Here's how to move safely and confidently during and after treatment.



Created by Accredited Exercise Physiologists

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70%

lower risk of treatment side effects with guided exercise

2019

ESSA position statement update on exercise in cancer care

8

gentle exercises you can start with

REST ISN'T BEST.

Exercise is now recognised as a core part of cancer care. Understanding why is the first step to moving with confidence.

2009

Exercise & Sports Science Australia published its first position statement on exercise and cancer in 2009. The evidence has grown so strongly since that individualised exercise is now recommended as standard care.

1

MOVEMENT BEATS REST FOR FATIGUE

Gentle activity eases treatment tiredness better than resting does.

2

TREATMENT COSTS YOU MUSCLE

Light strength work protects the strength and fitness treatment takes away.

3

YOUR PLAN IS YOURS ALONE

Cancer type, treatment stage and how you feel today all shape what's right.

MYTH VS FACT

MYTH

Rest is best during treatment.

FACT

Gentle exercise matched to your treatment and energy eases tiredness better than rest alone.

MYTH

Exercise isn't safe once you're diagnosed.

FACT

With a plan from an experienced AEP, exercise is safe for most people with cancer.

MYTH

There's one standard plan for cancer.

FACT

No single plan suits everyone. Yours should fit your treatment stage and how you feel.

CHECK WITH YOUR CARE TEAM FIRST IF

- ✓ Blood counts are very low or bleeding risk is up
- ✓ You have bone metastases or recent major surgery
- ✓ You have a fever, infection, or feel unwell

ESSA's position: a mix of walking-style exercise and gentle strength work, matched to you, is safe and helpful for most people with cancer when it's guided properly.

FOUR THINGS IT DOES FOR YOU.

Exercise doesn't just help you feel better day to day. It's increasingly recognised as directly supporting treatment outcomes.

1

EASES TIREDNESS

Research keeps showing that gentle, guided movement eases cancer-related fatigue better than resting does.

2

KEEPS YOU STRONG

Light strength exercise helps stop the muscle loss that treatment can cause.

3

SUPPORTS YOUR MOOD

Regular movement is linked to less anxiety and low mood, during and after treatment.

4

MAKES TREATMENT EASIER

Being fitter can make treatment easier to get through, and recovery between sessions faster.

WHAT YOUR PROGRAM CONSIDERS

Cancer type & stage — what's appropriate, and when

Treatment phase — before, during or recovery

Side effects — fatigue, nerve changes, lymphoedema

Your goals — energy, strength, what you love

The 2019 ESSA position statement moved away from one-size-fits-all: a plan built around your cancer type, treatment and current health gives the most benefit at the least risk.

DURING TREATMENT

Gentle, consistent movement on the days you're able

EARLY RECOVERY

Gradually rebuilding strength and endurance

ONGOING

A long-term, active lifestyle supporting overall health

START HERE.

Gentle exercises commonly used as a starting point in cancer exercise programs. Your Exercise Physiologist will tailor intensity, load and progression to you.

1

DIAPHRAGMATIC BREATHING

Slow, deep belly breathing to support relaxation, oxygen use and recovery between activity.

3–5 minutes, as needed

2

SEATED OR STANDING MARCHING

Gently march on the spot or seated, lifting knees to a comfortable height at your own pace.

2–3 sets of 30–60 seconds

3

WALL PUSH-UPS

Hands on a wall at shoulder height, gently bend and straighten your elbows to build upper body strength.

2 sets of 8–10 reps

4

SIT TO STAND TO SIT

From a sturdy chair, stand up fully then lower back down with control, using your arms for support if needed.

2 sets of 6–8 reps

5

RESISTANCE BAND ROW

Seated or standing, gently pull a light resistance band towards you, squeezing your shoulder blades together.

2 sets of 10 reps

6

STANDING CALF RAISE

Holding a chair or bench for support, rise gently onto your toes then lower back down with control.

2 sets of 10 reps

7

WALKING

Walk at a pace that feels comfortable, indoors or outdoors, building duration gradually as energy allows.

5–15 minutes, most days

8

GENTLE OVERHEAD REACH

Slowly reach one or both arms overhead as comfortable, to support shoulder mobility and posture.

2 sets of 6–8 reps



BEFORE YOU START

Always check with your oncology team before starting or changing your exercise routine. Stop and rest if you feel dizzy, unusually breathless or unwell, and skip exercise on days you have a fever or feel very fatigued. Work with an Accredited Exercise Physiologist experienced in cancer care for a program tailored to your treatment and needs.

BUILT AROUND YOUR ENERGY.

There's no fixed weekly plan for cancer exercise. It's built around how you're feeling each day, so this is a gentle structure to start from.

DAY	FOCUS	WHAT TO DO
MOST DAYS	Gentle	5–15 minutes of walking or seated marching, as energy allows
2–3 DAYS A WEEK	Strength	Wall push-ups, sit to stand, resistance band row, at a comfortable effort
EVERY DAY	Recovery	Diaphragmatic breathing and gentle stretching
LOW-ENERGY DAYS	Rest	Listen to your body: gentle breathing or stretching only

BEFORE TREATMENT

Building baseline strength and fitness can help you tolerate treatment better.

DURING TREATMENT

Gentle, consistent movement, adjusted day to day around energy and side effects.

AFTER TREATMENT

Gradual, guided progression back towards your usual activity levels and beyond.

FROM YOUR HEP TEAM

EXERCISE ONCOLOGY, DONE PROPERLY

Our Accredited Exercise Physiologists work alongside your oncology team to build a program specific to your cancer, treatment and goals, adjusted as you move through each stage of care.

BOOK ONLINE

www.hobartexercisephysiology.com.au

WHERE THIS COMES FROM.

Every recommendation in this guide is drawn from peer-reviewed research and professional body position statements.

01 Hayes, S.C., Newton, R.U., Spence, R.R. & Galvão, D.A. (2019) 'The Exercise and Sports Science Australia position statement: exercise medicine in cancer management', *Journal of Science and Medicine in Sport*, 22(11), pp. 1175–1199.

02 Cormie, P., Atkinson, M., Bucci, L., Cust, A., Eakin, E., Hayes, S., et al. (2018) 'Clinical Oncology Society of Australia position statement on exercise in cancer care', *Medical Journal of Australia*, 209(4), pp. 184–187.

03 Cormie, P., Zopf, E.M., Zhang, X. & Schmitz, K.H. (2017) 'The impact of exercise on cancer mortality, recurrence, and treatment-related adverse effects', *Epidemiologic Reviews*, 39(1), pp. 71–92.

04 Exercise Right (2019) *Cancer* [eBook]. Exercise & Sports Science Australia. Available at: exerciseright.com.au (Accessed: 2026).

A NOTE ON ADVICE

This guide is for general educational purposes and is not a substitute for individual medical advice. Always consult your oncology team and an Accredited Exercise Physiologist before starting or changing an exercise program during or after cancer treatment.